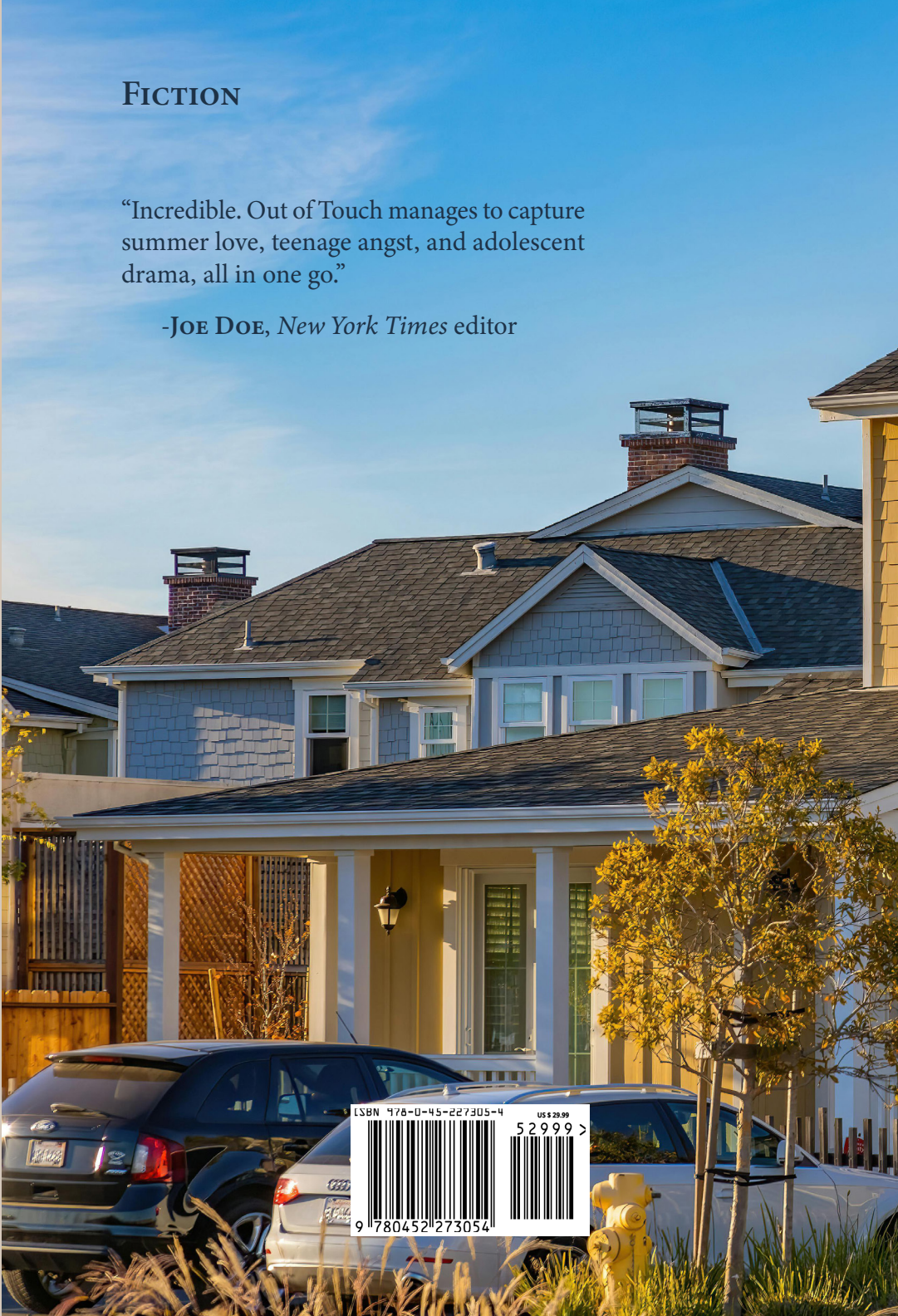




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FICTION

“Incredible. Out of Touch manages to capture summer love, teenage angst, and adolescent drama, all in one go.”

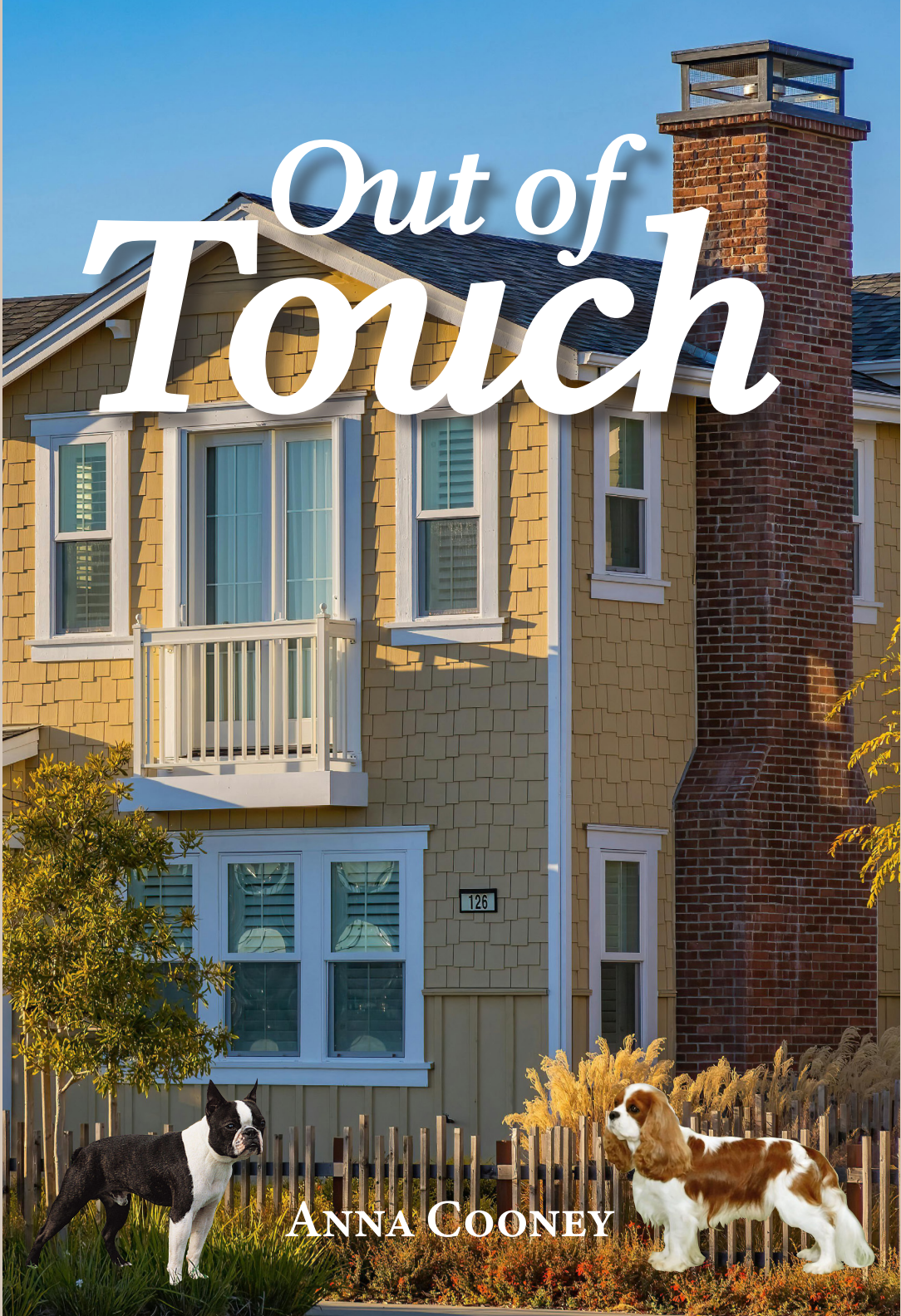
-JOE DOE, *New York Times* editor

ANNA
COONEY

Out of Touch



LEIDICH
PRESS



Out of
Touch

ANNA COONEY

U.S. \$20.00
CANADA \$30.00

Summer is meant for lounging at the neighborhood pool, crushing on the older lifeguards, sleepovers and handstands and prank calls. Summer is *not* meant for getting your heart broken and status as “girlfriend” replaced within a couple of months.

But what can you do when your meet-cute boyfriend decides you aren’t good enough? Well, for Josie, the answer is simple: you rot alone in your room and pretend the outside world doesn’t exist. And that solution worked. For one week.

Until Josie’s best friends barged into her room.

Until Josie attends her ex-boyfriend’s mock funeral.

Until a new shiny Mystery Boy moves into the neighborhood.

Josie knows that summer is meant for hopeless romanticism and that this unfortunate summer is meant for broken hearts. But maybe, just maybe, this summer is also meant for falling back in love, even harder than before.

“About two months ago, this would have been my saving grace. I would have coined this moment as my redemption-arc; my compensatory meet-cute. But now, I knew all of that was bullshit. And I was not falling for yet another shiny Mystery Boy.”

Out of Touch

ANNA COONEY

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For Lou.

Thank you for being the best dog in the world.

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Finally, I give thanks to all my friends, who allowed

me to share with them my project. Each and every one of them told me how cool this project and this class seemed, and I have to agree with them.

Foreword

Out of Touch is my dear friend Anna Cooney's first ever drafted manuscript. A ravenous reader and prodigious writer ever since our high school days, Cooney channeled her experience, imagination, and literary talents into *Out of Touch*, which she hopes will one day be her debut novel.

I first started engaging with *Out of Touch* in the summer of our senior year of college, after I saw Cooney had posted a TikTok about finishing the rough draft. I requested to read it shortly after, to which Cooney happily obliged me. I was overjoyed that she allowed me to read her most personal work yet, and even more delighted that she let me use its text contents as the basis of my first ever book design project. So, it will come as no surprise that *Out of Touch* shares a similarly sentimental place in my heart as in Cooney's, as this

manuscript is the start of many firsts, for both of us.

I have read several young adult novels, many of which fall into the same summery vein as *Out of Touch*. But none of those have been able to particularly capture the dog days of idealistic love, young heartbreak, and green beginnings, that always seem to roll around each summer, like *Out of Touch*. Each chapter made me crave the next, each emotion felt in the heart and in the gut.

I could go on; this foreword could stretch beyond the appropriately allotted one-to-two pages in the front matter. But the best way to experience *Out of Touch* is simply by reading, exploring, and enjoying it.

Prologue

Sweet Talk – Saint Motel

Hopeless romanticism had coursed through my blood since hanging onto empty pool ledges, gazing starry-eyed at the much older lifeguards above. To me, they'd always been royalty, perched high atop their sun-kissed thrones, completely unaware of the devoted jester lurking below.

I'd do anything for a laugh to escape their broad, tanned chests—poorly executed death dives, underwater handstands, even the occasional slamming directly into the wall during Marco Polo (which more often than not resulted in a nosebleed that called for the entire pool to be cleared and chemically shocked).

I didn't care if their laughter was at my expense. In fact, most of the time, I preferred it. Somewhere stored in my deluded, prepubescent mind, it felt like something I could control; something I could hold between

us despite our vastly different worlds.

In most social settings, I was my overly shy and timid self. But the neighborhood pool was where I thrived. When you're a kid, and you're about to give your first real speech in public speaking, every corny adult tells you to imagine that the audience is naked. And if you really think about it, a public pool is just about the closest thing to that reality. It felt like a fairground—a place where everyone was at equal risk for exposure. Which I guess in hindsight, gave me the confidence to make an absolute ass of myself.

Yet even as summer came to its inevitably unfortunate end, I'd try my best to keep myself occupied. The furthest I'd really ventured out was prank calling the upperclassmen, hanging up the second I heard the sound of their mature boyish voices (whose numbers I'd only obtained through my best friend, Natalie, who had just about every one of their younger brothers wrapped around her finger).

I mostly lived for the adrenaline rush that came the next day at school, brushing past them in the halls, wondering if I'd crossed their minds for even half a second as a possible suspect.

Needless to say, I liked my crushes out of reach. Just far enough fetched, but never too far out of mind. Because no matter how flawed my execution, I still had someone to think about when I was staring out the car window, romanticizing my nonexistent love life to the

soundtrack of High School Musical or whichever indie pop band I was currently hyperfixated with. So what if there was no one thinking about me on the other side? My make believe lovelife was near perfection.

Sure, when reality hit, that familiar achy feeling would resettle deep in my chest, amplified each time spring rolled around and my favorite upperclassman coupled up with an age appropriate girl for prom, or when summer came to an end and it was time to bid farewell to the lifeguard I'd spent all season not-so-secretly pining over. But it wasn't something I'd find myself losing sleep over. Because by crushing over guys I knew I couldn't have, I knew to be detached from expectations.

All until Lucas.

Chapter 1

Piledriver Waltz – Alex Turner

You Are The Right One had conveniently been playing on the overhead speaker the day my best friends and I made the fateful mistake of strolling into Pepperoni Palace.

Standing in line and waiting to order, it was only a matter of time before I spotted him, feeling myself becoming easily drawn.

His hair was brown and wavy, sticking out from the sides of his backwards Pepperoni Palace baseball cap, and he'd been humming along to the song on the overhead speaker, tapping his finger along to the beat of it alongside the register.

But what had struck me the most was that each time I'd tried to steal a glance at him, he'd already been doing the same to me.

I'd made the mistake of eyeing Natalie, to which she

immediately got that terrifying look in her eye. She and I had a way of understanding each other with just a single glance. Sometimes, I couldn't decide whether it was more of a blessing or a curse.

Once I'd finally ordered, and Lucas had read me my total, I wrestled for my debit card out of my comically small Ladybug wallet—a memento I hadn't been able to depart from since middle school—which naturally sent my card launching in the air, smacking Lucas right in the face.

I'd immediately apologized and could feel my face turning redder by the second as I buried my face in my hands, unable to look at him in his—luckily—unscathed face.

Yet as my own face burned crimson, Lucas let out a genuine laugh, assuring me not to worry about my *killer aim*.

I felt the adrenaline slowly start to fade from my face, my skin returning to its naturally olive-tanned color. But then of course, Natalie had to open her mouth.

"Don't worry—she's not always this clumsy," she'd told him through just about the loudest whisper and most mischievous of grins. "You just happen to be her type."

I'd stared at Natalie and then back at Lucas with sheer mortification. I wasn't sure there'd ever been a time I wanted more to disappear. Or strangle Natalie.

I couldn't even look at Lucas to determine whether he was still smiling sweetly or dramatically gagging with

repulsion. I'd decided I didn't want to know.

"She's joking," I'd said quickly, unable to get out more than three syllables.

But as the words hung between us, I felt his eyes concentrating over me. "That's a shame," he replied. "Really got my hopes up for a second there."

I had no idea what was happening. I just stood there in front of him, meeting my worried gaze to his; wide eyed gushing over the words that had just come out of his mouth. My equally supportive—yet slightly less delusional—best friend, Grace, had to remind me that I still needed to pay. "Hey Jos, ten fifty, remember?"

I once again apologized and handed Lucas my card. It felt as though he'd been staring into my soul as he handed me my water, and told me, "Try not to drop your drink too, Josie."

I stood there even more lovestruck than before, elated just to hear him say my name. It wasn't until an older man behind me in line shouted at him to "quit the flirting and hurry up" that both of our faces flushed, and I grabbed my drink and hurried away.

By the time we'd parted ways and sat down at our table, I was still completely in shock of what had happened.

We sat down at the furthest booth away from the counter, a conscious effort not to draw more attention, and I asked my friends for the reality check I figured I must have needed. But instead, Natalie began on a

rampage.

“What the hell was that, Josie? I had the bait dangled out right in front of you and he *clearly* wanted you to take it!”

I’d planned on blaming it on the long line behind us, and then the fact that I’d been starving all afternoon, desperately wanting to sit down and eat. But unfortunately, none of that could excuse the missed opportunity at hand: my one chance at a real life meet-cute. And I’d totally botched it.

I threw my head back against the booth, letting the tragic reality set in. This was all I’d ever wanted. And yet I’d passed it up for what? A rowdy line of customers and a mediocre slice of pizza?

I was left with no other choice.

I proceeded to not-so-confidently, but rather extremely nervously make my way towards the counter where Lucas was still ringing up a customer, and waited for the first chance he became available. Just as he handed the customer her receipt, I got his attention.

“Hey.”

Immediately, he jolted up from the register, his entire face lighting up as he did. “Oh... hey. You’re back.”

His adorable reaction made me even more nervous to mess up.

“Yeah... I was, uh... I was kinda wondering if I could get your number?”

My face felt like it was on *fire*.

“Wow.” He tilted his head as his mouth folded into one of those deep, amused smiles. “So your friend *was* telling the truth. What were you—just trying to tease me or something?”

The cheesiness of his reply shouldn’t have gotten me. But unfortunately, that deluded, idealistic, borderline desperate part of my brain reignited, overpowering any last bit of sense I had left in my fragile teenage brain.

And from that moment on, the rest was tragic history.



The next few weeks that followed mimicked alarmingly close to one of those cheesy montage sequences you see in every beloved romcom: the fun and games, the high on laughter, the feeling like you’re genuinely transcending space and time (not to mention the confused yet amused glances from the people around you, wondering what drugs you’ve been taking in secret and more importantly, where they could find them).

But as the summer progressed, things shifted in the way they always did, as Lucas began to pull me through the same repetitive cycle. He’d shift between extreme infatuation and complete indifference—blowing off plans one day but devoting the next to dramatically making up for it. I’d drive myself crazy wondering what I had done right one day but wrong the others.

For weeks I’d tried walking on eggshells around him,

desperately trying to protect what was left of our utterly flawed dynamic. I'd pretend not to notice the way he'd stop asking for daily run-downs of my shifts at work, or letting me in on the hectic details of his own. I'd especially try to hide the way my smile faded each time he'd forget about plans or details he'd sworn to remember. Until finally, I realized there wasn't much left to protect.

So I confronted Lucas about all the things that needed confronting about. And for the first time since we'd started talking, I was holding my breath again, praying I wouldn't say any of the wrong things.

I'd half expected him to cue one of his ridiculous diversions, to distract me from the fact that his demeanor had taken a full 180. But to my surprise, he didn't try to pull any of that. Instead, he brought me to the realization that I had apparently been blanking on all summer—he had only ever been playing a part. Because the moment I questioned his intentions, the act was over.

"Honestly, Josie I'm just not ready for this," he'd said to me casually, like some casual realization. "I think we rushed into things too quickly. And I'm sorry. I just think it's best if we end it."

And just like that, the only relationship I'd ever known ended over the phone like a tragic HR call.

I couldn't wrap my head around the fact that none of it had been real—mostly because I didn't want to. I had spent the first half of summer on cloud nine, parading around with him like he was some type of jumbo sized

carnival prize.

But while he had been pretending, fabricating an entirely false facade, I was letting my guard down for the first time, giving him the full ability to crush me.

I'd tried convincing myself that things had merely been left unsaid; that in a couple days, I'd wake up to hundreds of texts and calls from him, asking or rather begging me to work things through. But this ignorant bliss could only protect me for so long. Because in no more than a week, I was exposed to the cold, harsh reality: I had been replaced.

It was through this depressing new development, staring back at me through my lit up phone screen, when I realized that hurting me had likely never even been his intention. Instead, it seemed as if my feelings had never even crossed his conscience; he'd simply forgotten about them altogether. Forgotten about *me*. Which honestly, hurt worse than any cruel intention he could have held.

I felt reverted back to my old self again: the Josie who cautiously admired from afar, living vicariously through all leads in her favorite RomComs, but never truly getting to live out any of them.

Because lo and behold, I had only ever served as a placeholder; the emotional filler Lucas needed until he found someone better.

Worst of all, the summer romance my best friends and I had spent years anticipating had amounted to nothing.

Grace, Natalie, and I had all been friends since the sixth grade (Natalie and I since childhood being that we're next door neighbors), becoming inseparable once Grace switched out of home school and into our district, where we taught her the joy of middle school crushes.

Still as soon-to-be-seniors, we hadn't strayed too far from our old ways. We'd simply transitioned into high school crushes, still lacking any real experience in the dating realm. This being said, we'd spend all year waiting for summer—the time of year that we'd coined most serendipitous; a happy accident just waiting to happen.

And just as junior year had come to an end, Natalie had begun on one of her melodramatic monologues, swearing that this summer was “going to be different.” That this summer would be the one to “change everything.” And in a completely ironic way, she was right. This summer would change everything.

Chapter 2

If I Ever Feel Better – Phoenix

The only way I knew how to distract myself from this constant Lucas headache was by clocking into work. It had only been a couple of days since the rug had been re-swept from under my feet, but I had some faith that with the help of a distraction, today would be different—today I wouldn't dwell.

Ironically enough, I worked at Natalie and I's neighborhood pool, all with guys who had just about as much maturity as (at this point) I had sanity.

While I'd spent most of my summers admiring the lifeguards from afar, placing them on the highest of pedestals, the current staff had a few more quirks than I remembered the oldcomers having.

I had three male coworkers that I regularly worked with—Ryan, Jack, and Jonah. And while *I* considered them to be a bunch of brainless dopes, Natalie had

found her way to negate herself into *quite* the complicated love triangle with two of them—Jack and Jonah—AKA Beavis and Butthead.

For a bit of context, Natalie was usually unlike Grace and I—fearless when it came to guys. She'd approach them with one of her effortlessly flirty remarks, leaving both Grace and I in awe of her. But somehow, when it came to Jack, everything became foreign territory.

Natalie liked to blame this mysterious phenomena on the fact that Jack was a whopping *year and a half older*, except I knew that couldn't be the case—after all, she had no problem smart mouthing his best friend: Jonah. However, the trouble started on Memorial Day weekend, the first day the pool opened for the summer.

The day had started in the right direction with Natalie arriving at noon, just in time for the start of Jack's shift, where she'd confidently strutted her way through the entrance and elicited her first *real* conversation with the man of the hour.

As Grace and I watched from afar, we could tell that Jack was checking all the boxes—laughing at all her jokes, keeping a steady eye contact as she spoke, and appearing visibly engaged throughout the entire conversation. However, just as things were starting to look up, Jack threw Natalie a curveball.

In a totally casual way, he announced that Jonah sorta had a “thing” for her. And as she stood there speechless—which was a rare occurrence in itself—he

proceeded to ask her if she'd want him to "put in a good word" for her. To Jonah.

While this caused Natalie to go outright ballistic on the inside, she managed to put up a strong front. A little too strong of a front. Because instead of declining Jack's offer, she eagerly accepted. So much so that she devoted all of June and most of July to charming the hell out of Jonah.

Every afternoon was dedicated to flirting with him, banking on the fact that eventually, Jack would be fuming with jealousy. She'd push him in the pool, steal his hat, play footsie with him under the table—which more frequently than less made me want to projectile vomit—not to mention their choreographing of an elaborate dance number to Calvin Harris' *How Deep Is Your Love*, and making the entire staff including our supervisor watch.

However, after recent tragic developments, Natalie realized she needed to put an end to the act. She couldn't continue leading on Jonah the same way Lucas had done to me.

Needless to say, today wouldn't be any ordinary day at work. Today was the day Natalie would make things right.

Or at least attempt to.

By the time that Natalie finally arrived at the pool, Jack, Jonah, Ryan, and I were all sitting around the life-guard table.

It was a dreary day out, so not even the regular lap swimmers had shown, and because of the lack of action, we were all just sitting around at the table—Ryan and I ranting about our most feral residents, Jack and Jonah rambling about the previous night’s Yankee game. But once Natalie strolled in, all attention flocked to her. It was bound to. Natalie’s presence had a way of turning heads in even the most crowded of rooms.

She was visibly struck with this realization as she made her way to the table. She looked a little taken back by all of us just sitting there, all of our eyes just darting at her.

I shot her a weary look, as if through mental telepathy trying to tell her: *Let him down easy*. She shot me back a look that told me she was on board.

“Hey guys.” She smiled. Smiling as if someone was holding her at gunpoint to do so.

Immediately, Jonah disengaged from he and Jack’s conversation. “Uh oh, what’s that look for?” he snorted. “Hit Josie’s car or something?”

She studied his face as if trying to figure out if he was joking. Once she realized he wasn’t, she let out a long sigh, “No, Jonah. I walked here. I walk here everyday. I don’t exactly have a car or a license.”

Time to brighten your tone.

“But I do need to talk to you... .”

The tone of her voice told me she really did feel bad. Unfortunately, Jonah didn’t clock this.

“Aight,” he exhaled, proceeding to recline back in his chair, no concern in his voice whatsoever. “So what’s the sitch?”

Natalie stared at me hopelessly, anxiously twirling her long curly hair, and then back at Jonah. “Um... I was actually thinking we could talk somewhere more private?”

I knew it was going to be hard trying to get Jonah to take this seriously. The only times I had witnessed him in a serious demeanor was when playing ultimate frisbee with Jack or perfecting their not-so-secret handshake. While Jack and Jonah were best friends, who could at times be perceived as equally idiotic, they had one major distinction—their ability to read the room.

He once again made that *very* clear.

“I’m sitting here with my *boys* right now. There’s nothing you can say to me that you can’t say in front of them. Shoot!”

His boys?

Unfortunately, that comment was all Natalie needed to comply. “Well... okay. Guess I can’t argue with that logic!”

Abort mission. Abort.

But this time, she didn’t give me a look that told me she was on board. This time it was too late.

She began her confession. “Soo, Jonah. As I’m sure you’ve probably noticed, I’ve sort of been flirting with this summer...”

Jonah attempted to hide the gloaty smile that appeared as he answered, "Yeah. I've noticed."

"Um...okay. Great! Well, uh... I guess what I wanted to say is that I'm really sorry I've been doing that. Cause, uh...despite the flirting, I don't actually like you... like that."

There was a slight pause before Jonah spoke again. But when he did, boy was it heartfelt.

"Word."

Natalie stared at him with utter shock. "*Word?*"

"Word-up magazine!"

Ryan and I exchanged stunned looks from across the table. Jack on the other hand had his eyes glued to his phone, clearly only pretending not to be paying attention.

"You seriously don't care?" she asked. At this point, she sounded more offended than anything.

"Uh... why would I?"

Oh no. Wrong thing to say, Jonah. Stand down immediately.

No, she didn't like him, but a comment like that was bound to hurt anyone's ego.

"Um... maybe because I've been flirting with you all summer and you've been flirting back? I figured you'd be *somewhat* pissed if you found out that I didn't actually like you. Especially considering what Jack said about you having a thing for me..."

It was as if the mentioning of Jack's name had suddenly

engaged him into the conversation. He suddenly shot up like he'd just been electrically shocked.

Jonah furrowed his brow at him and then back at Natalie, for once in his life having to *force* a look of confusion. “*Me* having a thing for *you*? Nah. Must’ve had the wrong girl. It’s chill though. No hard feelings.”

I was just as confused as Natalie looked. But it didn’t seem like Jonah or Jack were in the mood to elaborate. Instead they just sat there, the both of them looking guilty as hell.

“Well... okay, then. Don’t know how that was *possibly* miscommunicated. But I guess that’s a relief!”

While I could tell that Jonah’s response had slightly humiliated her, I figured it was better than having to reveal the reason why she’d been flirting. Jonah seemed completely uninterested in the matter, and Jack sure wasn’t going to pop the question. But then of course, Ryan had to open his mouth.

“But wait, if you didn’t actually like him... why were you flirting?”

Immediately, Natalie’s eyes filled with dread. And hostility towards Ryan...

“Nah, Ryan, it’s chill.” Jonah brushed it off. “I was flirting back just for funzies. We’re all good.”

“Yeah, Ryan, he was flirting back just for *funzies*—we’re *good*,” said Natalie, not wanting to address his question for obvious reasons. “Besides, why aren’t you asking Jonah the same question?”

To that Ryan snickered. “Cause he has no reason! Jonah flirts with *everyone*.” He argued this as if it was some well known fact. But it really wasn’t. For starters, Jonah had never flirted with me (wasn’t exactly complaining about it though).

Apparently, Natalie decided now was the perfect time to read my mind. “Well that’s not true. He doesn’t flirt with *Josie*.”

The only thing more shocking than that was what came out of Jonah’s mouth next. “Yes I do!”

My eyes nearly bugged out of my head. “Jonah, what are you talking about?”

“Just the other day—I asked you if you wanted to look through my camera roll. To which you *rudely* said no by the way...”

“Jonah, that isn’t flirting.” I shook my head. “And of course I said no, I was on stand—I can’t exactly pretend to be amused by your camera roll while making sure that no one dies.”

“*Pretend?*” he scoffed. “I have some videos of me doin some pretty epic stunts. Ever heard of a roundoff backhandspring?”

“You asked her to look at your *camera roll*?” Natalie exclaimed, having a fully delayed but repulsed reaction.

“Damn. That’s intimate,” said Ryan. But his tone was far from serious—he was merely instigating—it’s what he did best.

“Why do you even care?” asked Jonah. “I thought you

were only flirting for funzies.”

“I *was*,” said Natalie. “I never said I cared. It’s just... weird. I mean, really? Flirting with my *best friend*?”

Oh the irony.

“Well it was never that deep!” Jonah cried. “It’s not like it actually *meant* anything. The only girl I really want is...” He hesitated before saying a name. “*Rachel*.”

We all fell silent. Painfully silent.

Basically, Jonah had this infamous on-and-off relationship with this girl in his grade named Rachel. Back in high school, their relationship had been the talk of the school. The two of them would break up every time one of them got too drunk at a party and became too touchy with someone else in their friend group, and then the cycle would start back up again.

“Dude...your ex?” Jack finally spoke up. He honestly looked more skeptical than surprised.

“Yeah... I know. It’s hard, man. It’s just, like, no girl compares to her. And I’ve tried flirting with *all* of them.”

How romantic.

“Fine. I guess I was wrong,” Ryan admitted, “Jonah did have reason to be flirting. But now that his reason is revealed, it’s time to reveal yours, Natalia!”

“No!” she shouted. “And do not call me Natalia. Ever.”

“Isn’t her motive kind of obvious now?” Jonah faked a yawn, acting as if he knew something we didn’t (which was always doubtful).

“Oh I’d actually love to hear this,” Natalie scoffed.

“You’ve only been flirting with me to spite Rachel—I saw the way you’d glare at her in the halls. I should’ve figured you were only plotting...”

Natalie’s eyes instantly filled with hot fiery rage. “First of all: keeping tabs on me and your girlfriend’s *eye contact*? You literal stalker! And second of all: you think I did all of this just to *spite* Rachel? That I’m jealous of that *miserable* being? Well *I* think you’ve lost your damn mind! I only ever glared at Rachel because she’s a *bitch*! Always has been! I mean, the girl bullied the freshmen all three years she retook Intro to Algebra. She even bullied elderly Ms. Hannigan! And I heard that woman was eligible for *sainthood*.”

So much to unpack here...

She probably should’ve held back. And refrained from talking out of her ass about sainthood. But in her defense, Rachel *was* a bitch. I had witnessed that girl publicly humiliate at least half of the student body in just the three years I’d gone to school with her. And yes, including sweet Ms. Hannigan.

The four of us stared back at Natalie in utter shock. Personally, I was just in awe of how spot on she was. But clearly, the silence was getting to her.

“Okay... that was a bit harsh,” she backtracked. But then, Jack let out a laugh. And that was all she needed. At that her eyes glistened.

“Never mind—Jack agrees!” she exclaimed, eagerly pointing in his direction.

Jonah whipped his head around in Jack's direction. "Are you... *laughing?*"

Jack struggled to think of the right excuse, until finally... "Well, she's kind of right!"

By the look on Jonah's face, I could tell that this was one of the highest forms of betrayal. "Well maybe if you agree with her so much you should just... *be* with her!" he blurted out.

"Not a bad idea..." Natalie murmured.

Suddenly, everything became clear to Ryan. He shot up in the air like a Looney Tunes character, his right arm raised in the air with his index finger pointed right in Natalie's face. "Aha!" he shouted. "So *that's* why you've been flirting with Jonah—the element of making his best friend jealous! You have the *hots* for Jack!"

At this point, Natalie's face matched the shade of our bright red bathing suits.

I sent a disapproving look in Ryan's direction. We were usually allies, but just now he had crossed the line.

"Is that... true?" asked Jack, almost looking afraid to.

Natalie buried her face in her hands, until eventually, she decided to just come clean. "Well *yeah* it's true. Like... embarrassingly so. But you tried to set me up with Jonah—I can take the friggin hint already. You don't have to—"

"I didn't try to set you up with *Jonah*."

Natalie's eyes widened. For a minute I thought I was going to witness an actual brawl. "Uh, you sure did! You

not only told me that Jonah liked me, but then asked if I'd want you to *put in a good word*—sounds like a set up if I've ever heard one!"

"Well to me that sounds like an *offer*. An offer which you *eagerly* accepted."

Natalie whipped her head around in disbelief and then back at Jack. "I'm sorry, but why would you *offer* to set me up with him if you didn't *actually* want me to say yes?"

"Why would you accept the offer if you didn't actually want him?"

Suddenly, a resident appeared by the entrance, clearly unsure of whether or not it was safe to pass through.

"Can I sign in?" she asked hesitantly.

"Yes, of course! Name and address, please?" Ryan asked, smiling warmly as if we'd all been sitting here casually and not in fact screaming at each other.

But once she gave us her information, the chaos endured.

"*Why* were you asking me for a *REACTION*?" Natalie cried. The reason was kind of obvious now. Even Jonah had figured it out.

"Because he *likes* you." He rolled his eyes.

For a split second, I'm pretty sure I saw Natalie's soul leave her body. "Actually?"

All eyes swarmed to Jack for confirmation.

"Well, yeah... actually."

At this point Natalie had to pull out a chair and sit

down.

Ryan began to scratch his head. “So even with that whole being super popular, good looking, and well-liked thing you got goin’ on... you couldn’t just tell her how you felt?”

His comment was completely disregarded. Natalie began to process it all out loud.

“So you’ve liked me. You’ve liked me this entire time. This *entire* time I’ve been trying to make you jealous, you already liked me.”

Grace’s car then pulled into the parking lot.

Boy, did she miss a lot.

She’d anticipated getting here just in time for the inevitable drama to subside. Little did she know she was still arriving at its peak.

“I guess you could say I’ve liked you for a while...” Jack admitted.

“How long we talkin?” Natalie raised a brow. “Weeks? Months?”

“Hey, guys...” said Grace, wearily walking in from the entrance, without a doubt sensing the high tensions. “What’s going on?” she mouthed to me. She then glanced over to the woman swimming in the pool.

“Do you guys know there’s a lady swimming laps right now?”

“I’ve been eyeing her every couple of seconds—she’s *fine!*” Ryan insisted.

Although startled, Grace didn’t question anything.

She pulled up a chair from a nearby table and sat down, to which Natalie immediately resumed her heated interrogation.

“Let’s not get distracted here, Jack: how long are we talking? Days? Months?...Yesterday?”

Jack took a minute to think. Or perhaps decide how honest he wanted to be. “I mean... I guess I’ve sorta had a thing for you ever since that year we had gym together. Being around you all summer just... heightened it.”

Natalie’s jaw dropped. As did the rest of ours.

“I’m sorry, *what* did I miss?” Grace exclaimed.

I couldn’t recall the last time Grace had intentionally interrupted a conversation, let alone this heated of one. That’s how you know this one was good. I decided to debrief her.

“Natalie admitted to Jonah that she’s been leading him on, Jonah didn’t care, Jonah still has feelings for Rachel, Natalie then completely violated Rachel, Jack laughed, Natalie’s motive for flirting with Jonah was exposed, Jack revealed he never meant to set them up in the first place, and as you just heard, Jack has liked Natalie since *sophomore* year. Oh yeah, and apparently a guy showing a girl his camera roll is *super* intimate.”

I was pretty sure I had summed up everything. I finally caught my breath.

“*What?*”

“I mean, I thought the camera roll thing was common knowledge.” Jonah shrugged.

"I don't care about *that*. I care about Jack and Natalie! I mean, Jack liking Natalie since *sophomore* year? Sophomore year Natalie would've *died*!" Grace exclaimed.

"Natalie right *now* would've died!" I shared her excitement.

"I'm right here..." Natalie reminded us. "And so is Jack."

"It's cool," Jack shrugged. But he was still blushing.

I glanced over at Jonah who looked like he was just about ready to hurl, then, back at Ryan.

"So... what does this mean?" he motioned to the two of them.

Natalie and Jack exchanged dubious looks, clearly wishing for the other to answer. Finally, Jack stirred up a proposal. "Wanna meet my dog?"

"Sure!"

To that Jack grabbed his keys and twirled them around his finger. "I'll drive!"

"Duh!"

And just like that, Jack and Natalie were off, exiting with the sound of Jack's beat up Camaro and upbeat techno music.

As the sound grew further and further in the distance, Jonah began to sulk. "I remember when *I* was his dog."

We all slowly turned our heads towards him, Ryan staring at him with an extra pitying look. "Jonah, you're his *dawg*. You were never his *dog*."

Slowly, Jonah shook his head. "I was his dog. When

we were kids, Jack would always beg his mom for one, but she told him he wasn't responsible enough. So occasionally, I'd walk around on all fours and pretend to be a Cocker Spaniel. It seemed to make him happy."

We were all silent for a good couple of seconds.

"Jonah, *what?*" I exclaimed.

"*Specifically* a cocker spaniel?" Grace felt the need to clarify.

Jonah just shrugged. And for some odd reason, we all sorta let this concerning piece of information slide, staring off in the distance reflective of recent events.

"Y'know, it's a five hundred dollar fine to swim unsupervised, right? You could've just waited!" Ryan called over to the lap swimmer.

Clearly, he didn't fear losing his job. But the lap swimmer didn't hear anyways. She couldn't have—she had earplugs in and a determination to master her breaststroke.

"So..." I stared off. "That really just happened, huh?"

"Which part?" Ryan looked up. "Jack and Natalie happening or Jonah revealing his furry alter-ego?"

Jonah let out a defeated sigh. "I should call Rachel. But I need to be alone. Catch you, brodies."

"You need to be *alone*?" Ryan exclaimed. "I thought we were your boys!"

"Nah, now we're his 'brodies,'" I corrected him.

Jonah took one last glance at us before finalizing his decision. "Eh, I'd stay but my main brodie just dipped.

Besides... now Grace is here.” And to that he grabbed his keys and began to head out the gate.

He proceeded to do his signature Jonah waddle all the way into the parking lot. He was always walking like he had just pulled something.

“What the hell does that kid have against me?” asked Grace, sounding rather offended despite her complete indifference to Jonah.

“I wouldn’t worry about it,” I said. “He’s *Jonah*.”

Ryan let out an amused smile. “Just picture him walking on all fours.”

Just picture him walking in general.

By the time my shift was over, which Grace had accompanied me for the entirety of, Natalie texted us letting us know that she was heading back from Jack’s.

Once he dropped her off, she couldn’t run through my front door quick enough, clearly eager to let Grace and I in on all the juicy details.

Apparently, Jonah and Rachel had crashed their hangout midway through and caused *quite* the debacle. But once Natalie lost her shit and had practically hauled Jonah and Rachel out of the house herself, things seemed like they’d worked out perfectly.

I was so happy for them. And at the time, so distracted. All of this excitement over Jack and Natalie had made me forget about my own love life. Until it didn’t...